

The Empty Nest - Printable Sheets

From *The Empty Nest* by Ruth Callahan (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

THE FIRST-TERM CALENDAR

What tends to happen, and what helps. Write in your own dates - the known hard points are much easier to handle when they are expected.

When	Date	What tends to happen	What I have planned
Departure week		Adrenaline, logistics, often flat rather than tearful	
Week 1-2		The quiet house. Mealtimes are the worst part	
Week 3-4		Often worse than week one. The homesick call	
Week 6-12		For many, the hardest stretch	
First visit home		Not what you pictured. Friends come first	
The second goodbye		Reliably harder than the first	
Christmas		Strange even when everyone is there	
Boxing Day - mid Jan		The emptiest fortnight of the year	
February		Most often described as the low point	

Spring		The new shape starts to feel normal	
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The six-month date - the earliest I will decide anything major: ____ / ____ / _____

THE SIX-MONTH DECISION LIST

Things I am NOT deciding yet. Write them down so they stop circling.

The decision	Revisit on

The house. The job. The marriage. The dog. The room. Six months, then decide.

THE CONTACT AGREEMENT

Agree this out loud, early, and write it down so neither of you is privately keeping score.

Our standing catch-up is: _____ (day and rough time)

Between then, we:

If I do not hear from them, I will assume:

My own rules, decided now while I am calm:

- No second message within _____ hours
 - No escalation until _____ hours, unless there is a real reason
 - I will not open with: *have you eaten / did you hand it in / are you sleeping*
 - Instead I will send:
-

The sentence if contact really drops:

"I've noticed we haven't talked in a while. I'm not having a go. I just miss you and I'd like to hear how you are." - once, then leave it.

THE MONEY LINES

Clarity beats generosity. An unspecified arrangement makes every request a fresh negotiation.

What we provide

What	How much	How often	Until when

What is theirs to cover:

If it runs out early, what happens (decide now, not in the moment):

Things to hand over to them on a date

Thing	Handover date
Phone bill	
Subscriptions	
Insurance	

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The sentence for a no: *"I'm not going to do that. I'm happy to help you work out how to cover it."*

THE WEEKLY CONVERSATION SHEET

For restarting the habit. One a week, in the diary, not in front of the television.

Week	What we did	Children banned for one meal?	Something new we tried
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			

Things worth actually talking about - tick when you have:

- ☐ What the next ten years look like
- ☐ Money, now the costs change
- ☐ What each of us has missed
- ☐ What we each want this stage to be
- ☐ Retirement - and whether our answers match

TWENTY QUESTIONS

One over dinner. Not twenty in an evening - that is an interrogation. Answer first; do not interrogate the answer.

#	Question	Asked
1	What do you actually want the next ten years to look like?	
2	Is there anything you gave up for the children you would like back?	
3	What was the best year of your life so far, and why that one?	
4	What do you wish we did more of?	
5	Is there anywhere you still really want to go?	
6	What am I good at that I do not notice?	
7	What has changed about what you want from work?	
8	When did you last feel properly proud of yourself?	
9	What do you worry about that you have not told me?	
10	Is there anything you have been putting off saying?	
11	What did you think our life would look like by now?	
12	What do you miss about how we were?	
13	What is better now than it was then?	

14	When do you feel closest to me?	
15	Is there something you would like us to stop doing?	
16	What would you do with a completely free year?	
17	What are you looking forward to?	
18	What do you want retirement to look like?	
19	What would make the next year better for you?	
20	Is there something you want to try that you think I would say no to?	

THE BOOMERANG AGREEMENT

For when they move back in. Agreed **before** they arrive, not after the first row. Treat it as a flatshare with people you love.

Roughly how long: _____ **We will**
review on: ____ / ____ / _____

Money

What	How much	From when
Contribution to the household		
Their own phone / car / insurance		

Household jobs - who does what

Job	Who
Their own laundry	
Their own room	
Cooking - which nights	
Cleaning - which parts	
Shopping	

Guests:

What they do NOT have to report: where they are going, when they will be back, who they are seeing. They are an adult.

What we do ask: let us know if you will not be in for a meal or overnight - the same as any flatmate.

The check-in sentence, used early rather than at eighteen months:

"I think this has drifted. Can we talk about how it's going and what the plan is?"

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